to return to Los Angeles and head Jones's architecture firm.

In the absence of any indication that something attractive was in store for him at the Tata Group, Ratan took the job offer seriously. But deep down, he was uncomfortable about taking a gamble and starting all over again. He had already spent around seventeen years in the Tata Group. Besides, the architecture firm already had other associates and there would have been resistance to any outsider being foisted to the top of the firm. He, therefore, let the opportunity go.

However, Ratan maintained very close relations with Elaine until she died. Recalling the bond he and Elaine shared, Ratan says: 'Every time I'd go to the US, I'd go to Los Angeles. There was the Hyatt within walking distance from their [Quincy and Elaine's] house. I stayed at the hotel, and I'd go and meet with Elaine and take her out to dinner … almost till the end.' In December 1987, Elaine even made a trip to India, in Ratan's words, 'to surprise me on my fiftieth birthday'. When she was diagnosed with Alzheimer's and somebody cheated her of her house, Ratan stepped in, supporting her financially and meeting her at every opportunity, according to Shireen.

Betting on Ratan

By 1978, Ratan had gained a reputation in the Tata echelons as a thinker and a visionary. The contours of the Strategic Plan helped build this reputation. While he was gaining more respect, the chairmen of the large Tata companies were jockeying to succeed JRD when he stepped down. They were anxiously playing the power game, hoping to be chosen to head TIL and, later, Tata Sons.

By 1980, JRD had spent forty-two years at the apex and was seventy-six years old. He had slowed down. Realizing that he would have to work on finding a successor, in October 1980, JRD launched a search for the TIL chairman.

There were many contenders. Some were heads of the larger group companies who had earned accolades for their significant contributions. The others were stalwarts of Bombay House.

The heavyweights considered to be in the fray were the legendary Sumant Moolgaokar, seventy-five, chairman of TELCO; the flamboyant and irrepressible Russi Mody, sixty-three, MD of TISCO; Nani Palkhivala,